

The New Idioms OF LOVE

We are too fascinated by the West to understand the real dynamics of relationships in an Indian cultural context

— By **PATRICIA UBEROI**

In India, you often hear that marriage in the West 'no longer has any meaning'. After all, one-third or more of marriages result in divorce. Sociologically speaking, the high divorce rate doesn't mean that people have lost faith in the institution of marriage. Rather, they have ever higher expectations of it. And they tend to do it more often too, sometimes with children (his, hers and theirs) in tow. While marriage remains a thriving business in the West as elsewhere, it is important to be attentive to the new idioms of married love. Apparently it is no longer the ring, the ceremony or the certificate that demonstrate a committed relationship, but a joint bank account, the joint

purchase or lease of a house, and (the acid test) shared pin codes and e-mail passwords. In post-modern societies, such actions are believed to constitute the ultimate material demonstration of unqualified trust.

Sociological recognition of the materiality of conjugal and familial relations has not come easy in the West for it goes against a deeply ingrained cultural assumption that love and money, sentiment and commerce, intimacy and rationality are polar opposites whose mixture can only result in their mutual contamination. Yet practical life and legal necessity have forced a rethinking of this assumption. Is a commercially arranged marriage any less of a marriage? Does writing a marriage contract betray a lack of trust in the relationship? What rights does a rent-a-womb mother have over the child she bears? Under what conditions

can a sperm-donor redeem his rights as a biological parent? Can a paid care-giver or even a caring partner make claims on an estate over legal but neglectful heirs on grounds of having performed that familial role? Would a child's nanny be a more natural custodian of an orphaned child than distant relatives?

Issues such as these, where everyday values often conflict with the law of the land, are being constantly argued and tested, and they have particular piquancy in cross-cultural contexts. For instance, the visa queue at the US or UK embassies in New Delhi reveals many young couples staggering under the weight of giant photograph albums which are meant to demonstrate that theirs is not a marriage of convenience for immigration purposes even if they have hardly ever been alone together. As a precaution they

● With over 10 million couples getting married in India each year, the wedding industry was on a 45 per cent growth path in 2007.

14%
was the rise in the divorce rate in India in 2007 as against five per cent in 1980.